GOD ON SPEE

FROM LONG-DISTANCE PRAYERS TO AI-POWERED *KUNDLIS*, GEN-Z'S ANXIETY IS CREATING A NEW MARKET FOR DIGITALLY-ENHANCED WORSHIP AND ASTROLOGY

By SONALI ACHARJEE



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

At 29, Kavya Sethi, a banking professional from Gurugram, has begun consulting an AI pandit before major decisions, including a job change and planned PPF withdrawal. When a difficult planetary phase was flagged in her *kundli*—a Vedic birth chart calculated from a person's date, time and place of birth—she chose a prayer tailored to it. "There is already so much anxiety around work and money," she says. "If I know a difficult period may be coming, I would rather prepare for it. It makes me feel I have done something instead of just waiting."

That instinct—to prepare ritually for uncertainty rather than turning to faith only after something goes wrong—is becoming more visible among younger urban Indians. As jobs feel less secure, healthcare more expensive and parenting more competitive, many are turning to worship for a sense of control. Doctors have expressed concern around the rising rate of C-section deliveries, partly due to '*muhurat* caesareans' — elective procedures timed to astrologically favourable birth charts. Online platforms offer karmic consultations for job exits, baby names, entrepreneurial success and breakups. *Kundlis*, *graha dashas* (unfavourable planetary combinations) and *muhurats* (ideal periods for new ventures) are, of course, centuries old. What feels contemporary is the level of individual tailoring around them.

This trend sits within a wider anxiety about getting life decisions right. Earlier generations did not have to deal with social comparison as it's experienced today, what with a perennially digital existence that's inextricable from physical interactions with your friends and colleagues. The usual anxieties are given new life every time you reach for your phone and log on to social media: somebody else has been promoted, bought a house, moved abroad, found a partner or built a seemingly more successful life. "Young people today are being asked to make very high-stakes decisions in an environment where very little feels guaranteed," says Dr Upasana Chaddha of Mindscape Counselling Centre, Delhi.

PRIVATE LINE TO HEAVEN

Vivek Shukla, founder of PujaPurohit, a prayer booking platform, says around 40 per cent of all prayers on the website are now personalised to one's needs and wants, and more than half the users are under 35. The average cost of this service is Rs 1,000, inclusive of the equipment required for